



TOUCHING
Go Out
GRASS

The *Lore*

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Words of
Caution and an
Invitation to
Go Out

The phrase “touch grass”, once an internet jibe to go outside and get real, has become a genuine cultural rallying cry. After years of relentless time online, what was once an escape from reality has turned into a space people are stagnating mentally in. There’s a palpable analog renaissance underway, a collective lunge toward reality. This report tracks what that swing back looks like in India, and what it demands from us.



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IT BEGAN WITH
FATIGUE.

Rewriting the rules of Going Out

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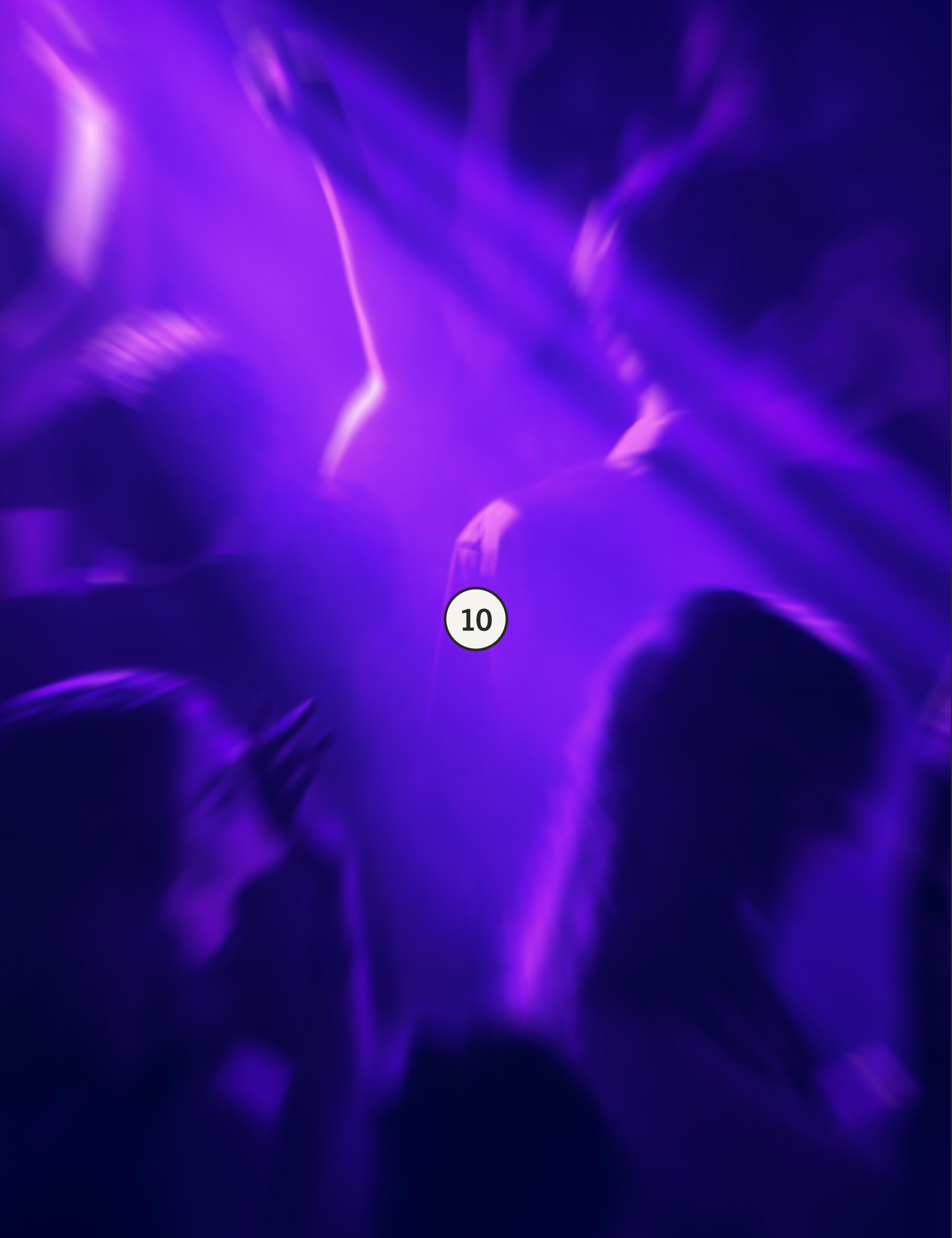
Every choice, from where you go, to when, and how long you linger, reflects how you see yourself and the world you want to inhabit. This is grounded intentionality.

On any Wednesday night in an Indian metro, a run club, a supper club, and a gig are quietly redefining what “going out” means. After a decade of hyper-digital living and algorithmic sameness, urban India is resetting its social codes, renegotiating how we spend our time outside the house, and what that time says about who we are.

This offline reset did not begin with a backlash or rebellion, it began with fatigue. People realised they were overstimulated but underwhelmed, constantly connected but rarely moved. Small, private moments, closing Instagram without knowing why, skipping stories, staying in on weekends, walking without headphones, cooking without documenting, made people discerning. Discernment is now reorganising culture. A new going-out culture is emerging, fluid, emotionally

intelligent, and sensorial. Across metros, young consumers are assembling rituals that bring them back into their bodies, their cities, and each other’s company. Going out is no longer just an escape, it is a form of authorship.

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A Tuesday-night gig can signal as much taste as a once-a-year festival, and a quiet coffee at 8 AM can hold as much social electricity as a cocktail bar at midnight. Social value is increasingly about how you arrange your time, not just where you go.

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Status by schedule is becoming a new form of status signalling.

After years of digital noise, people are gravitating toward experiences that feel rooted, human, and unfiltered. They want to try new things without fear of looking amateur. Across metros, this desire shows in small but telling ways: the rise of spaces where you can arrive alone, the ease of slipping between solitude and community in the same evening.

Arriving alone is no longer coded as loneliness. It's autonomy. It's a quiet confidence.

Underneath these choices is a new rule of status: validation is moving offsocial. The proof of a good life is shifting away from posting. Validation is increasingly felt in the body, via energy, mood, stimulus. Identity still shows up online, but more as fragments than a performance. People are leaving a light trail of belonging rather than a public broadcast. The new flex is proof-of-life.

This attitude has broadened the idea of a “good night out” beyond nightlife itself. Mornings, afternoons, post-work hours, dawns, and the liminal

in-betweens have all become viable, even desirable, social spaces. The city is no longer a weekend stage. It's an always-on environment for becoming.

We're witnessing a generation rewriting the unwritten rules of going out. They crave openness in taste, the chance to drift in and out of communities, and permission to experiment with identity. India's young cultural consumer is digitally native, aesthetically fluent, and globally attuned, and wants experiences that don't just entertain but transform.

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This report steps into that landscape, observing how India goes out now, and what that reveals about ¹⁴ who we are becoming ¹⁵ across a few key Shifts.

These shifts aren't "trends" in isolation. They are interconnected.

Read on to see how India will go out in 2026 and beyond.



Plot-First **CULTURE**

The new luxury is a story. It can come with a steep price tag but the old currency of the spend guaranteeing status will fade. The new social capital has shifted to provenance. Experiences will have to invest in world-building in this new Stimulus Economy.



You're among the curious first to taste-test a cold plunge rave. You don't buy a pair of sneakers for its logo. You sign into a subculture that reflects your discernment. Here, there's no safety net protecting you from perception. The new sign of luxury is being earnest in your quest for the experience.

Earnest clout becomes a new form of status.

For years, digital innovation chased one north star: frictionlessness.

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One-tap delivery. Personalised recommendations. Instant music. Bingeable shows. Hyper-efficient shopping. Feeds that knew your taste before you did. Convenience became the central promise of modern life.

But convenience has a ceiling. When everything is effortless, nothing feels earned. When everything is available, nothing feels scarce. When everything is visible, nothing feels intimate.

Algorithms spent a decade sanding down friction and handing us novelty on demand. Eventually, novelty on demand starts to feel predictable. A feed that knows your taste too well stops surprising you. Friction does the opposite. It introduces uncertainty, and uncertainty keeps the outcome alive.

That's why travel produces stories. Dinners produce anecdotes. Local gigs produce lore. Markets **21** deliver discovery. New sports create camaraderie faster than small talk ever could. Friction injects randomness. Randomness creates surprise. Surprise sticks as a memory. And memory is where value forms.



You can feel it in the formats rising right now. Earned experiences, be it queuing for a dessert, waking up at 5:30 for a run club, trekking seven hours to reach a campsite, learning film processing, cooking for ten strangers leave you with memory imprints.

This is where the new allure of friction being sexy comes in. Not because it's hard for the sake of it, but because it

22

demands presence. You can't half-attend a real thing. You have to show up, commit time, stay long enough for the night to turn. That's the difference between consuming an experience and living inside it.

District Logout is District's attempt to build a deliberate exit from the digital haze. A series of tightly curated, one-off gatherings for a select audience, designed to pull people back into the room.

Presence becomes social value

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These aren't parties or gigs in the usual sense. They're distinctive cultural meetups shaped around community, ritual, and presence, with just enough mystery to feel like you've stepped into something coded. A quiet ingroup forms naturally, not through gatekeeping, but through the simple act of showing up. presence

becomes social value. Presence-maxxing rises because you can't fake being there. This also links to a parallel social shift: anti-screentime signalling. Screen-time is starting to read as lame, passive, low-agency, while going out reads as choiceful and alive. It becomes a visible preference for the world over the feed.

MICRO

TREND

#01

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Collision ECONOMY

The defining sentiment of this decade is stimulus. Everywhere you turn, someone is trying to sell an idea, an experience, a personal brand, while others are reviewing this effort. The overexposure is exhausting. But this creates a feedback loop where the only thing that provides momentary escape is the promise of never-seen-before stimulus.

Just the thought of skipping the incessant dissection of a trend to live a brand new idea that is yet to make it big is thrilling.

Think of it as playing a game of chase, where you want to move onto the next before the crowd catches on. You can call it the first movers advantage. This desire for constant renewal has manufactured a new breed of novelty.

Culture is developing a faster novelty metabolism: what once lasted a season now lasts a week, but the hunger stays constant.

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Here, protagonists from polar opposite worlds collide together to defeat boredom. Think of the coffee shop raves that lit 2025 abuzz only to crash into irrelevance a few months later. The prototype may have died down, but the model is only gaining steam. People crave the shock and surprise of unlikely pairs coming together, and creators are more than ready to fill in the gaps.

Kink studio Silly Hands Shibari hosted a retreat in Rishikesh that combined a pleasure lab with pottery classes. The luxury grocery store Foodstories offered blind folded water tasting backdropped to an in-house ⁽²⁶⁾ rave while Mumbai's Crab Culture took the DJ console into the Borivali local train. Everyone may be doing sound healing, but Chennai's wellness clinic Satva elevates the experience by hosting it on pool floats. This juxtaposition of parallel worlds

is also flooding into flavour. Two of Bengaluru's most coveted spaces, Naru and 23rd Street Pizza, came together to create ramen inspired sourdough slices. Yes, you read that right.

(27)

The internet has made audiences accustomed to rapid dopamine hits. People want to rage against the machine but find themselves drawn to its flourish. In response, going out culture is distilling neo-hedonism into the blueprint.

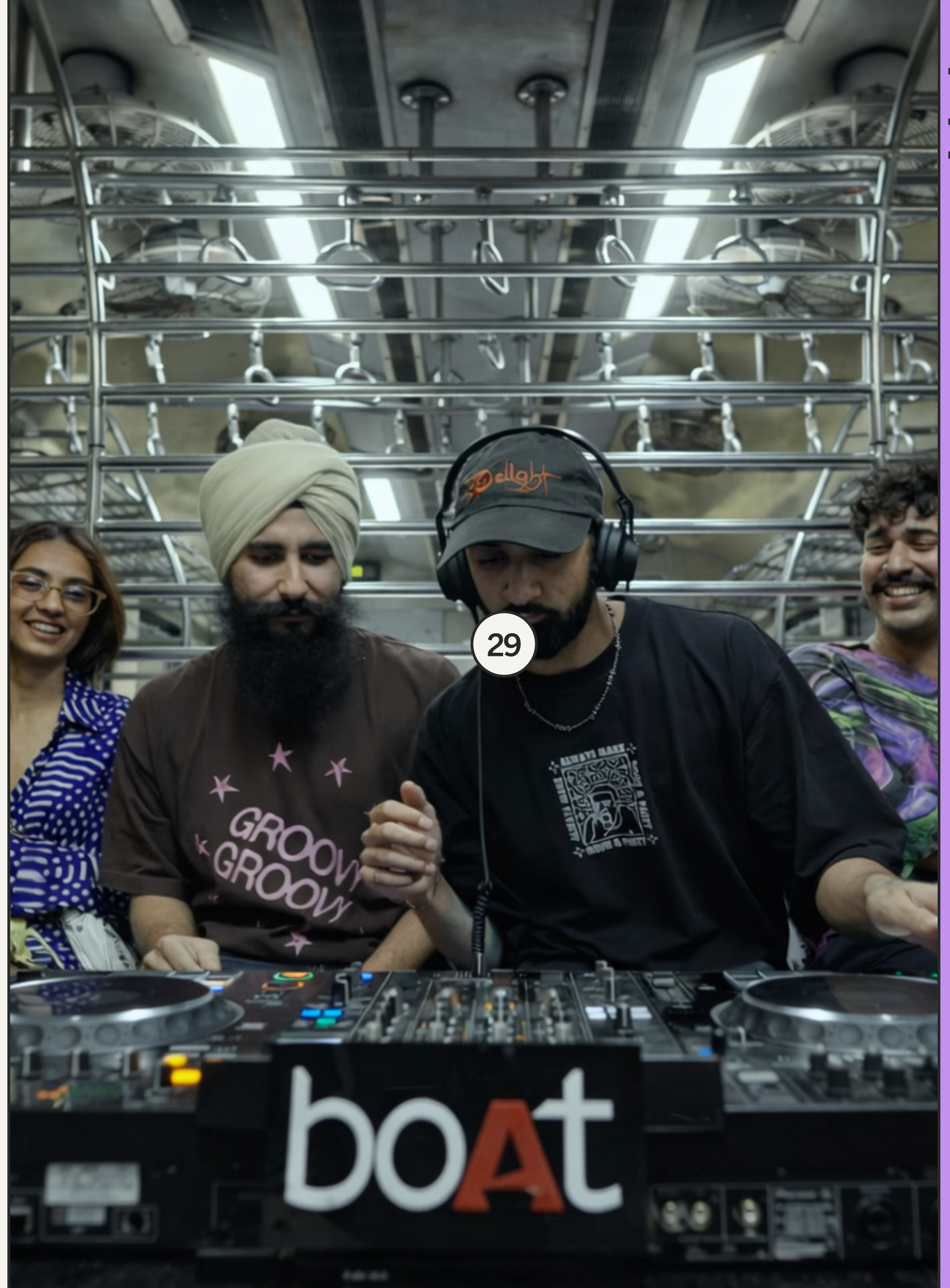
This contemporary trend centres the pursuit of pleasure, only now the route there is unique. A coffee is no longer espresso and milk. It is topped with a dollop of ghee and served to you inside a sauna. In the era of tiny attention spans, the experiences that cut through the noise scratch more than one itch.

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The event itself may run out of steam in a hot minute, but it's the underlying feeling that matters. People want novel ways to tap into thrill. The core is the same. Only the clothes change, and collision becomes a lever to create this stimulus.

The market is stimulus-heavy, so novelty has to be smarter than XYZ + Rave = Hit. Unlikely pairings work when they feel like world-building. Create collisions that have a logic, a tone, and a reason to exist over gimmicks and audiences will do the amplification for you.

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Performative male flooded culture just as people were healing from the surplus of girl-trends. One day it was cool to eat olives for dinner, the next it was romantic to be bad at math. One day it was cringe to be cheugy, the next ³² it was cringe to say the word cheugy. In total, it is all consuming to keep up with the changing codes of social capital. More so to constantly behave detached from this system when, in reality, it remains a powerful source of validation.

Audiences are finally ready to step away from this race of cringe-avoidance and nonchalance. Tangible, offline novelty is enabling this shift.





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This beginner energy has manifested in going out culture through new ways of interaction. People who have never played sports open themselves to testing their limits with pickleball and padel. Others join run clubs, celebrating micro milestones from Strava and being honest about the struggle and joy of learning something new.

*Today, the
coolest thing you
could ³⁵ do is
log out and
be earnest.*

People are increasingly okay with looking silly for the plot. The overarching sentiment is that engaging with novelty trumps the fear of being cringe. It is better to try something new and fail than to stay safe and predictable. This is plot-first living: try anyway, in public, with people.

This trickles into the pursuit of knowledge as well. See POV, the India-wide community that brings deep lectures on the surface of the moon to a pub.

“We function as an occasional gallery and host creative workshops,” says Malini Malik, the founder of Bengaluru-based design store General Items.

This rejection of cringe is also visible in the quest for friendships. Years ago, using Bumble BFF was seen as a derogatory sign of social isolation. Now it is certifiably cool to attend stranger mixers and make the first move.

“People ³⁶ enjoy the space because ³⁷ even if they don’t buy objects, they leave having learnt something. Audiences enjoy the educational component and are secure enough to wear it proudly.”

- Malini Malik



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Proof OF LIFE

Going out has started behaving like authorship. With endless choices on tap, the restaurant you step into signals more than good food. It signals who you are when you're left to your own taste.

Where you go, where you are seen says more about you than what you broadcast.

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Choosing to discover a traditional Korean hot pot over your usual Indo-Chinese haunt reads as appetite for novelty and a desire to experiment. Handpicking clothes from an artisanal craft store instead of ordering them online is also a

testament of consumer value. The places you go double up as proof-of-life. They build your cultural autobiography. As people invest more thought and stakes into going out, spaces are taking note too.



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Friendships and dating are taking cues from the same shift.

Group chats keep you tethered, but depth comes from shared experiences.

The pregame before a gig. The festival you planned all summer for. The collective silence during a film scene that landed. These private references become social glue. Memes still circulate, but they don't hold the weight they used to. Experiences stick. Online is upkeep, Offline is where your bond deepens.

This is also where a new social metric is quietly being rebuilt. Going out is returning as a marker of being socially functional: well-adjusted, interesting, dateable.

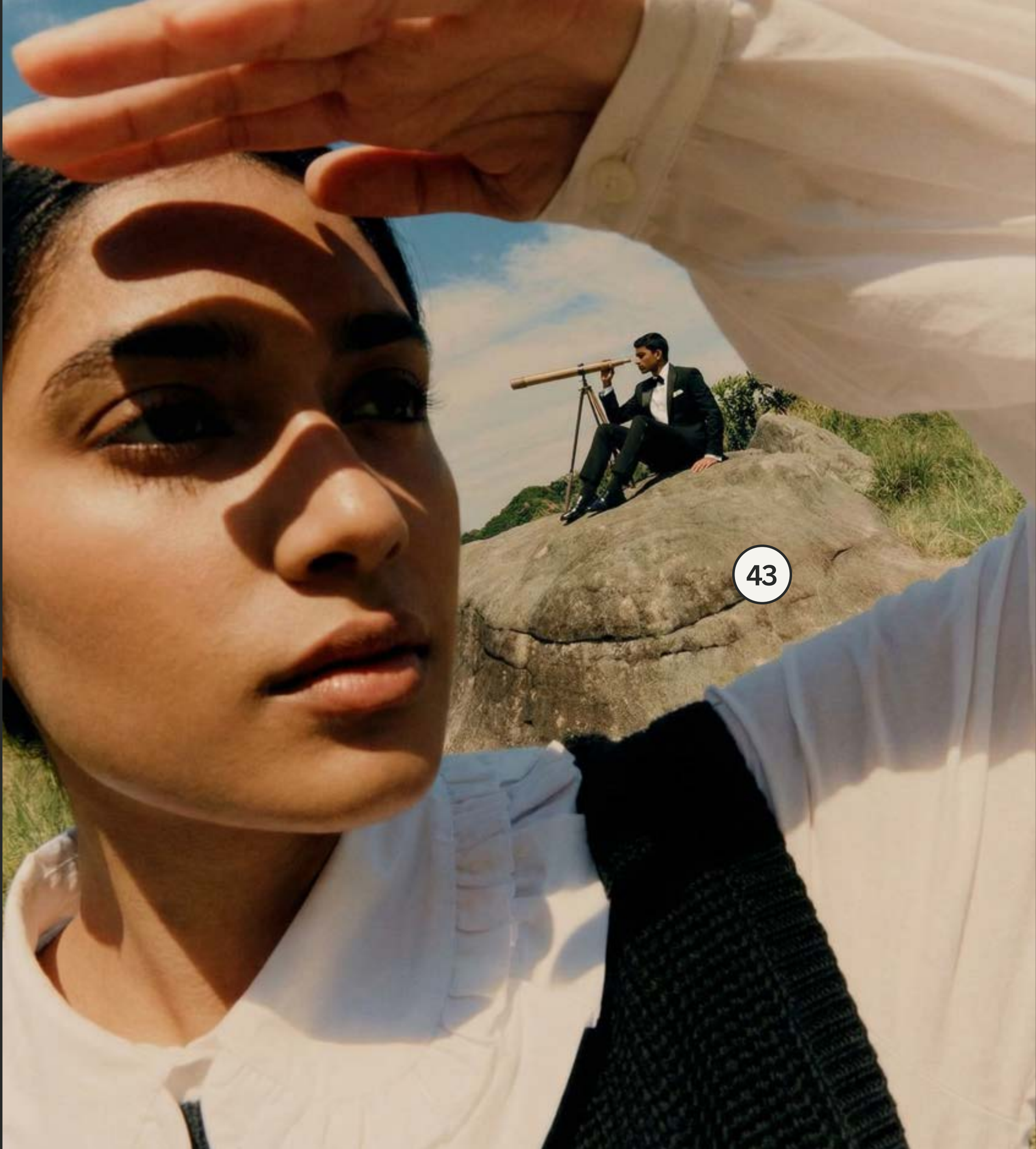
It has become an unspoken eligibility signal. Call it a going-out credit score, the quiet rating of compatibility you earn through IRL presence.

Dating makes this especially visible. The zeitgeist has moved past treating compatibility like a set of prompts. People still swipe, sure, then they look for what can be observed. This is where the IRL Compatibility Score begins forming. It’s behavioural.

Does this person have interests aligned with mine? Do they have taste that lives outside a screen? Do they step out and explore the city like I do?

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You learn it in small bursts. In how they handle a waitlist. In whether they can enjoy a place without trying to prove they belong there. In how quickly conversation drifts away from internet consensus and into something lived, something

(44) only they could say. Reliability (45) shows up here too: planning, committing, being on time, carrying a night from one chapter to the next without turning it into a logistical meltdown. It reads like social aptitude or fitness. Proof that they can participate in real life.

46

Ambient **BELONGING**

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The desire for connection remains top of mind, but the rules of engagement have shifted. You don't need to be part of a group chat or walk in with a plus one because company is no longer the price of entry. People are opting for low-pressure, low-stakes environments that provide the structure of togetherness without actively asserting commitment.

Touching grass sits closer to baseline behaviour now. Going out feels intrinsic to being a well-adjusted individual: someone with curiosity, stamina, and a working social nervous system. It signals you can move through the world with ease, read a room, hold your own, meet people halfway. In a culture where screen-life can swallow whole weeks, stepping out has become a quiet tell. You're present. You're engaged. You're participating in real time.

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A table at the right restaurant, a ticket to the right festival, a flight to the right city began to function like products in a cart. Interchangeable units of taste.

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The instinct, naturally, was accumulation. Do more, go everywhere, stack plans like proof. Millennial minimalism gave way to post-millennial materialism, shaped by post-pandemic revenge urges. The purchase still carried status, but the object had changed. It was now a reservation, a wristband, and a boarding pass.

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In 2023, we hit a strange plateau: the equivalence of experience as things.

What's emerging now is a cleaner, sharper posture. Less volume, more composition. People are shifting from collecting experiences to curating an experience map. Going out starts behaving like an identity assembly. You pick spaces that reflect who you are, what you're curious about, and the kind of life you're trying to build. The goal is specificity, not saturation.

This is the era of the communal nomad, where belonging isn't linked to an inner circle but to a shared rhythm.

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This shift changes the room. Experiences start concentrating people who arrive with higher intent. Not passive attendees filling time, but participants who want to engage, contribute, and belong. That density of attention becomes rare, and rare attention becomes valuable. For platforms, artists, fandoms, subcultures, and brands alike, this is the new prize: mindshare that lasts, travels, and turns into repeat behaviour.

The humming synchrony of a live audience, the quiet comfort of a coffee-shop counter, and the earnest freedom to break social hierarchies on the padel court or at a supper club dictate the new markers of fitting in. Lean on designing for the in-between: the person who wants people around them, not necessarily people with them only. Growth will come from formats that make entry feel easy but still feel real.

GOING OUT



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SIGNALS IDENTITY

83%

Of Indian Gen Z choose
trainer-led community
fitness classes that
feature high engagement

54

Marriott International,
The Future of Food, 2025

61%

Of Indian diners value
interactive elements
like open kitchens and
chef interactions

The live events sector currently
valued at

142 BILLION RS.

is expected to exceed

235 BILLION RS.
BY 2027

55

EY, A Studio Called India, 2025

The number of concerts in India is expected to rise from

14,470 IN 2024

TO 24,520 BY 2030

EY, A Studio Called India, 2025

In 2024,

42%

Of movie goers watched
films on the release day to
foster belonging

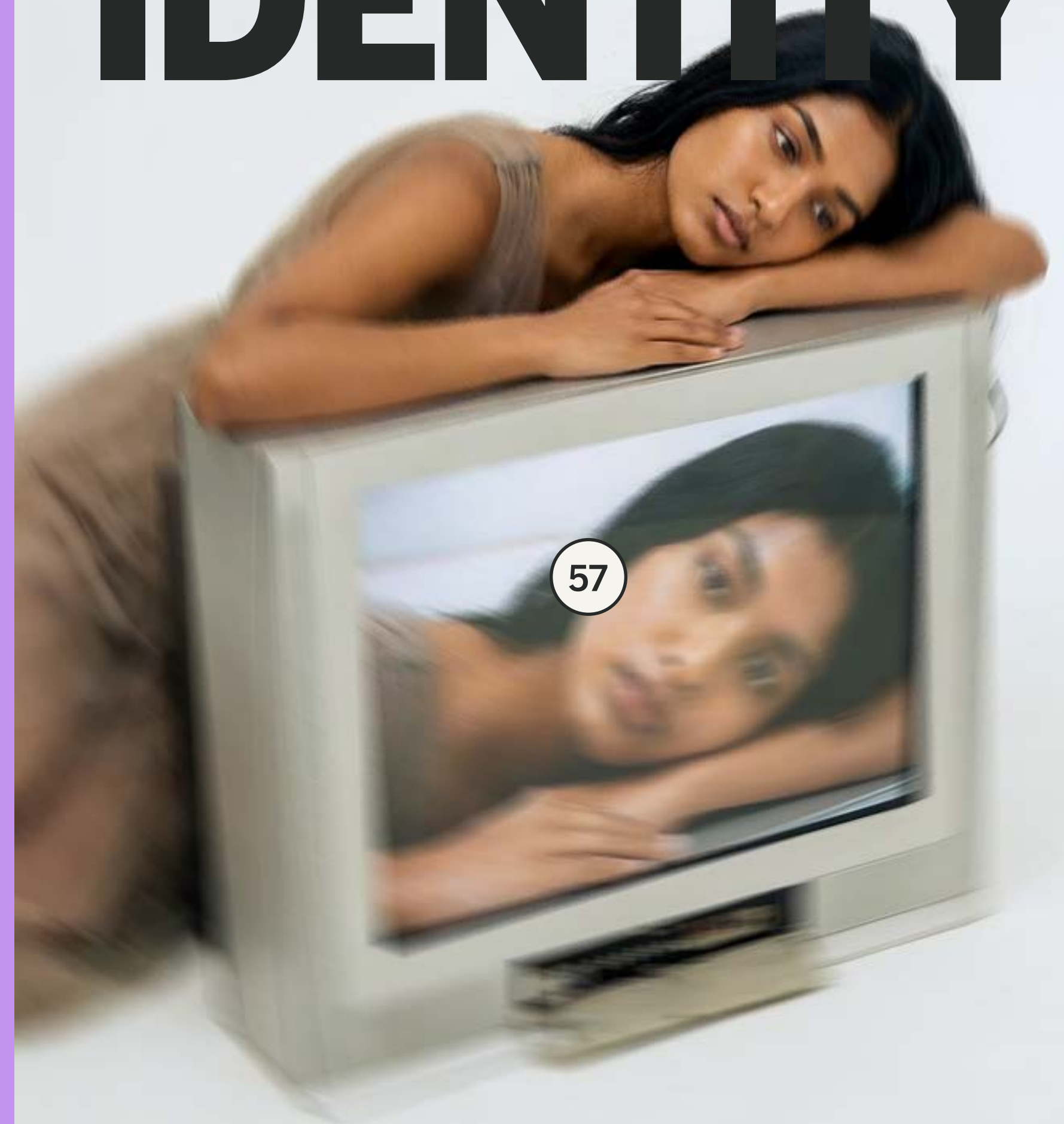
GroupM India,
Profiling Cinemagoers, 2025

Years of doomscrolling and data mining have manufactured the digital self into a cage.

56

Algorithms force-fit identity into predictable content and the same old behaviour, holding people within illusory online worlds. The real world then becomes the escape hatch from this algocaging, the desirable reset button where you can break out and test-drive a new look, a new vibe, a new crowd. In this context, going out is no longer about proving who you are. It's about experimenting with who you could be. Social spaces should design low-pressure structures that make interaction easier without forcing intimacy. It's not "make friends" energy. It's "walk into a room where conversation can happen if you want it to". It gives people permission to participate without pretense.

IDENTITY



57

SCAFFOLDING

4/10 consumers we spoke to look forward to meeting new people through daily, & sustainable engagements like, over a pottery or art workshop, or a new sport.

58

People are assembling pods of identity, small clusters of interests that give them codes, rituals, and communities: run pod, cinephile pod, food nerd pod, desi hip-hop pod, play pod and so on. You don't miss out on anything if you skip a large concert; there is enough variety to feed your identity instead of just showcasing it at one event or space. Going

out becomes the mechanism to feed and expand these pods. People are kicking the conventional buckets and exercising fluidity in taste. For decades this power of discovery warranted courage and community. People leaned on partners to step out of their comfort zone, and those without felt beholden to a prescriptive identity. But no more.

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Today, you, just you, no frills, no terms and conditions, no catch phrase, is absolutely enough to shuffle personalities and play until you decide to settle. In part, people have to thank the slow surge of fourth spaces for this shift. The internet has revolutionised social gathering. Previously, third spaces dictated the meeting ground. Now they have made way for hybrid

phygital communities that may begin online, anchored in common interests, but come alive in true glory offline. This blend is growing on the back of social scaffolding. People are building environments that support or at least cue easy interaction.



IDENTITY

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IS

POD-BASED

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NOW

Think of Bengaluru's Eleven AM Club that invites guests to come together once a month to creatively express themselves, whether it's colouring, scribbling in your journal, or people watching for inspiration. The event separates output from activity to spotlight the shared ritual of creating together. Similarly, Kaunversations, a gathering company that spreads from Ahmedabad to Chennai, hosts brunches where strangers play social card games to move one step closer to each other. Elsewhere, open mic nights, film clubs, or crochet circles root interaction in interests. Even sport lends itself to this quality. Pickleball and padel, games that have skyrocketed to fame in recent times, seamlessly enable social exchange by being partner activities.



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Dining is also encouraging audiences to discard the safety of a group. At Papa's, the intimate Mumbai 12-seater, attendees find specially curated reading material full of opportunities to colour, doodle, or nerd out. While Bombay Daak consciously rejects the quintessential high bar stools in favour of comfortable low seating, reminding solo diners to take their time and linger. Whether you stay for an hour, nurse a drink, or move between venues, the script is yours for the writing. There is no pre-life baggage spilling into your experience or telling you how to behave. You can renew and you can retreat at your own pace. The new premium is ease of entry without social risk. Spaces and formats that provide rituals, and gentle interaction cues will see an uptick in love from audiences.

Together ON DEMAND

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Digital culture has crafted fragmented everyday experiences where one person's algorithm could be poles apart from their neighbour's. This dissonance furthers a feeling of isolation and anxious separation where each individual can feel sequestered on their own island.

As people struggle to navigate remoteness online, the real world provides the opportunity to bridge the distance. Audiences are mourning the loss of monocultures, the shared ritual where everyone experienced a singular emotion together.

When the Indian women's cricket team won the World Cup in 2025, Mumbai witnessed a recreation of this relic from the past. People who may have

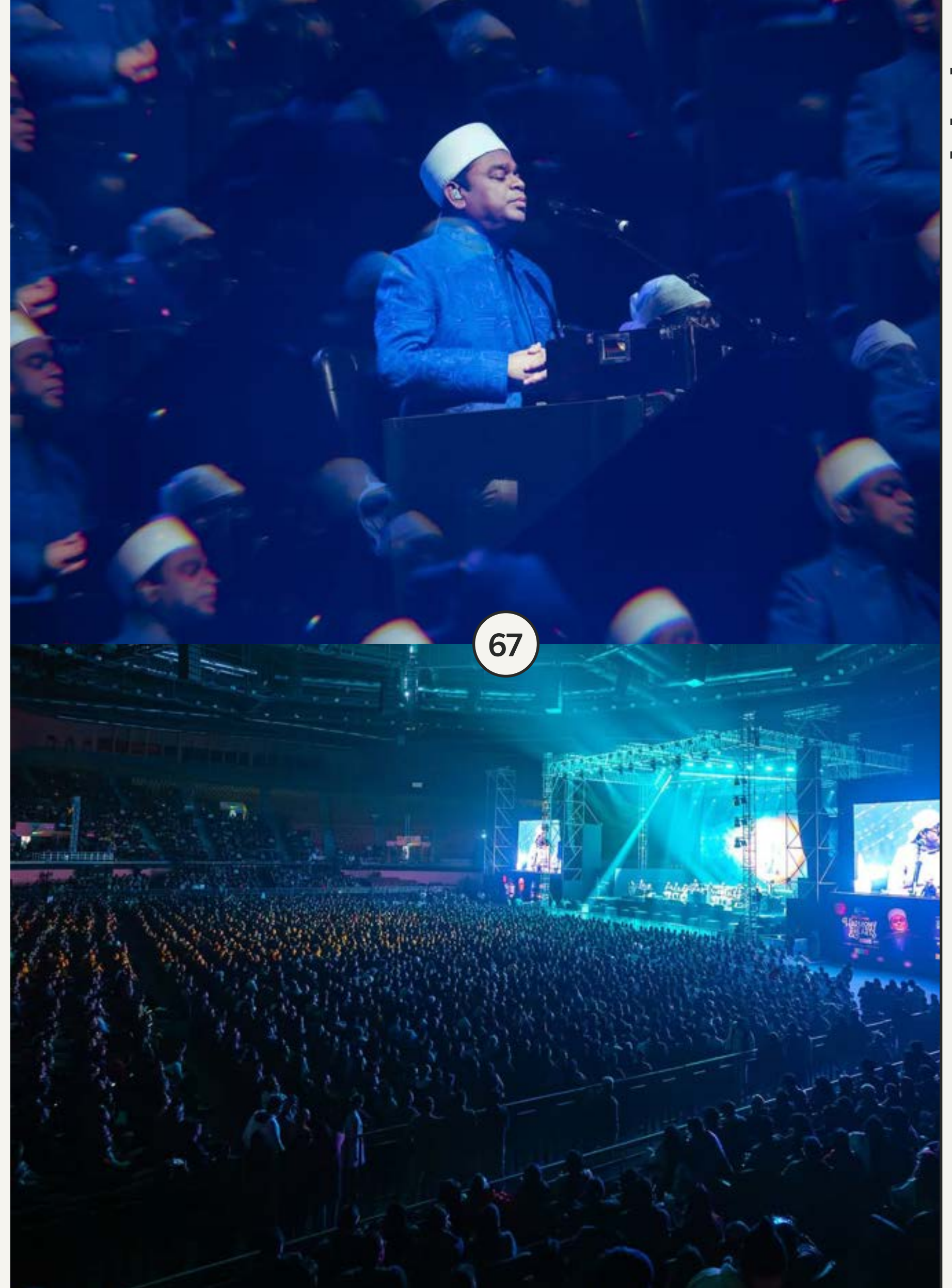
Think of the euphoria evoked by the shared rhythm of a crowd clapping, chanting, and moving together.

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never watched the sport were tied together in celebration, and strangers found warmth in the closeness of a crowd united by a shared feeling. But this experience is rare and people no longer want to wait for decades to tap into social belonging.

Audiences are harnessing this feeling by leaning towards plural micro cultures rooted in concerts, cinemas, and community play.

Irrespective of how many or how few songs people know by an artist, they invest in gigs to experience the oneness of a crowd raising their arms in the air as wrist bands glow under the night sky. Fandoms are bending ⁶⁶ their once rigid rules to welcome trespassers. Here, culture becomes the social glue. You don't need deep expertise or exclusive access to join in. You can participate slowly and still feel included.



Even if you are a quiet vibe seeker, resisting the urge to whistle and clap, you're suddenly sitting a little easier in your seat. There's solace in knowing you belong to a larger group, and relief in the reminder that you're never entirely alone. It's no surprise that cinemas are re-releasing old classics and hosting week-long celebrations in ode to actors' birthdays. These milestones give audiences a chance to come together without the pressure to perform their fandom. Unlike a group of friends that may expect you to remember every line of your favourite film, the stakes are low and safe with strangers. You can show up exactly how you want and that's enough.

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“It can feel like a similar experience that you would get in a stadium when you’re supporting your favourite football team.”

Kamal Gianchandani, the CEO of PVR Pictures Limited.

70

“Most people come to theatres because they want to escape from their everyday, the quality of a film can transport them to another world. I think they will continue to become more immersive.”

71



72

This feeling of togetherness without actively asserting yourself is often easiest to conjure in a cinema. People seek small-scale belonging: a knowing smile, a nod, a shared reference point. You don't need to know someone's name or age, but when your favourite actor turns up on screen, you are bound by familiarity and joy.

73

Build repeatable “everyone felt that together” moments, and you’ll earn the most powerful currency right now: timestamped memory.

Solo SURE

74

As traditional social structures are deconstructed, arriving alone isn't seen as a sign of loneliness but autonomy.

The move asserts a quiet confidence where going out is no longer a means to pad your social prowess but to flex your curiosity.

Solo-sure is a permission structure



for the self.

Once upon a time the 0.5x on your phone was a record of how many people fit into your frame. Today, it is a testament to driving yourself to unfamiliar grounds. Typically, if you walked into a vinyl cafe and heard an artist you didn't recognise, the first instinct would be to privately Shazam it. But now, people are actively rewiring their response to walk up to the DJ and kick off a chat. Asking questions to build know-how reflects agency, and spaces are equipping themselves to match this interest for conversation.

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Gone are the days where fine dining was a strictly quiet, restricted activity. Dining is increasingly anchored by chef- and bartender-driven experiences where flavour is only elevated by boisterous chat. Bengaluru's Ma La Kitchen, a supper club inspired by the Sichuan region of China, rejects the standard peer introduction in favour of specificity. The chef shows you his most prized artwork from the province and invites you to flip through his library while serving tea that is reminiscent of nostalgic family traditions. This means the kitchen isn't backstage. It's now part of the show and creates countertop communities.



77

Similarly, Papa's, the coveted 12-seater dining experience in Mumbai, dismantles the hierarchical, one-sided channel of communication from guest to server to manager to chef.

“Since the ‘70s, the structure of a restaurant has been split into the stove ⁽⁷⁸⁾ and front of the house. This divide has diminished free flowing conversation. At a place like Papa's, you can understand the experience first hand from the chef”

Hussain Shahzad, Executive Chef at Papa's, The Bombay Canteen, O Pedro and Veronica's.

“But the exchange doesn't end there. While guests may be inquisitive of just how long a grape was pickled, often the conversation flows from travel and current affairs to how the political climate is shaping the food industry.” ⁽⁷⁹⁾



Indulgence for individuals has driven the economy of the solo sure - one can see this in the considerable rise in solo dining, solo concert going & solo travelling.

80

22%

Of 2025's concert goers headed out solo



81

A streetwear space like VegNonVeg isn't merely about transactions. The artwork on the walls and the visual merchandising warrant curiosity and conversation.

Bengaluru's spin studio Chakra Athletica consciously hosts salad workshops, treks, and other outside-class activities that encourage athletes to befriend their coaches.

Outside dining, this quest for expert encounters bleeds into retail and play. There is no longer a wall of intimidation between the specialist and the newbie. This fluidity allows you to mutually disengage from your inner circle to dwell on social soloing. The opportunity is to engineer experiences that feel complete at 1x and irresistible at 2x. Solo-sure doesn't thin crowds; it raises the bar for experiences that work solo and deepen socially.

DUAL *Prime* TIMES

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Social clocks have been reset. The city now operates on dual peaks where it's just as valid to blow off steam on weekdays as it is on weekends. Tired 9 to 5 schedules that pushed interaction to the end of the week are a thing of the past. As wellness enters the everyday, the fabric of socialisation is widening to welcome conscious care, no matter the time. With sunrise runs and mid-week matinees, AM culture is growing alongside traditional PM nightlife. Plans are no longer linear. They are stacked to make space for elastic schedules and diverse interests. A single outing is now a multi-chapter experience: a museum visit that runs into dinner that ends at a gig. Luxury lies in the freedom to switch between hustle and leisure.

83





This is the lived reality behind the earlier claim: weekends don't own culture anymore.

84

Midweek is valid. Mornings are valid. Liminal hours are valid. The monopoly of Friday and Saturday is breaking because time itself is the flex.

Time embedded, not time killed. This is status by schedule made visible. If mornings and midweeks are now culturally valid, then programming can't be weekend-dependent anymore.

40% of dining out across metro cities now happens during the week.

Dinners v. Lunches & breakfast combined are almost at a 50-50 split now.

85

Razorpay POS Report, 2025

Dining out on weekdays has risen by 33% across metro cities revealing the rise of mid-week catch ups.

86

FREEDOM IS *Elastic*

Social calendars have been frozen in time. People have abided by prescriptive time blocks for different strands of life. Work was top of mind from Monday to Friday. Drinks were reserved for evenings, preferably Friday or Saturday to safely accommodate a slow morning the following day. Vacations were strategically peppered throughout the year, most likely to coincide with a long weekend and maximise time off. Serendipity was few and far between. These mapped out life sequences are slowly becoming dinosaurs from the past.

Five years ago the pandemic unlocked a new world of working and its scars still echo in schedules. Companies may have returned to the office, but people are resisting

losing agency over their time. Audiences on disparate rungs of the social ladder aspire for this freedom. It's no wonder that flashy cars and logo bags no longer denote luxury. True wealth is slowly but surely becoming synonymous with control over calendars, for both productivity and leisure.

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Instead of living by rigid instructions, audiences crave play in their everyday through spontaneity and thrill. Providers respond by introducing whimsy in classics. Quintessentially evening restaurants like Muro are opening up for breakfast, serving dimsums with maple syrup. KNMA hosts matinee film screenings while big movie debuts often feature dawn shows that start as early as 3am.

Enrique Iglesias' Mumbai gigs were interestingly held on Wednesday and Thursday nights, attracting over 25,000 visitors. For years, work was associated with productivity and leisure reduced to time pass. Today, going ⁸⁸ out is equally seen as immersion, a means for lore-sharpening that contributes to personal growth. As people vie for elastic timings, plans are getting stacked. One evening becomes a micro-journey: a gig at a comedy club flows into a midnight street food



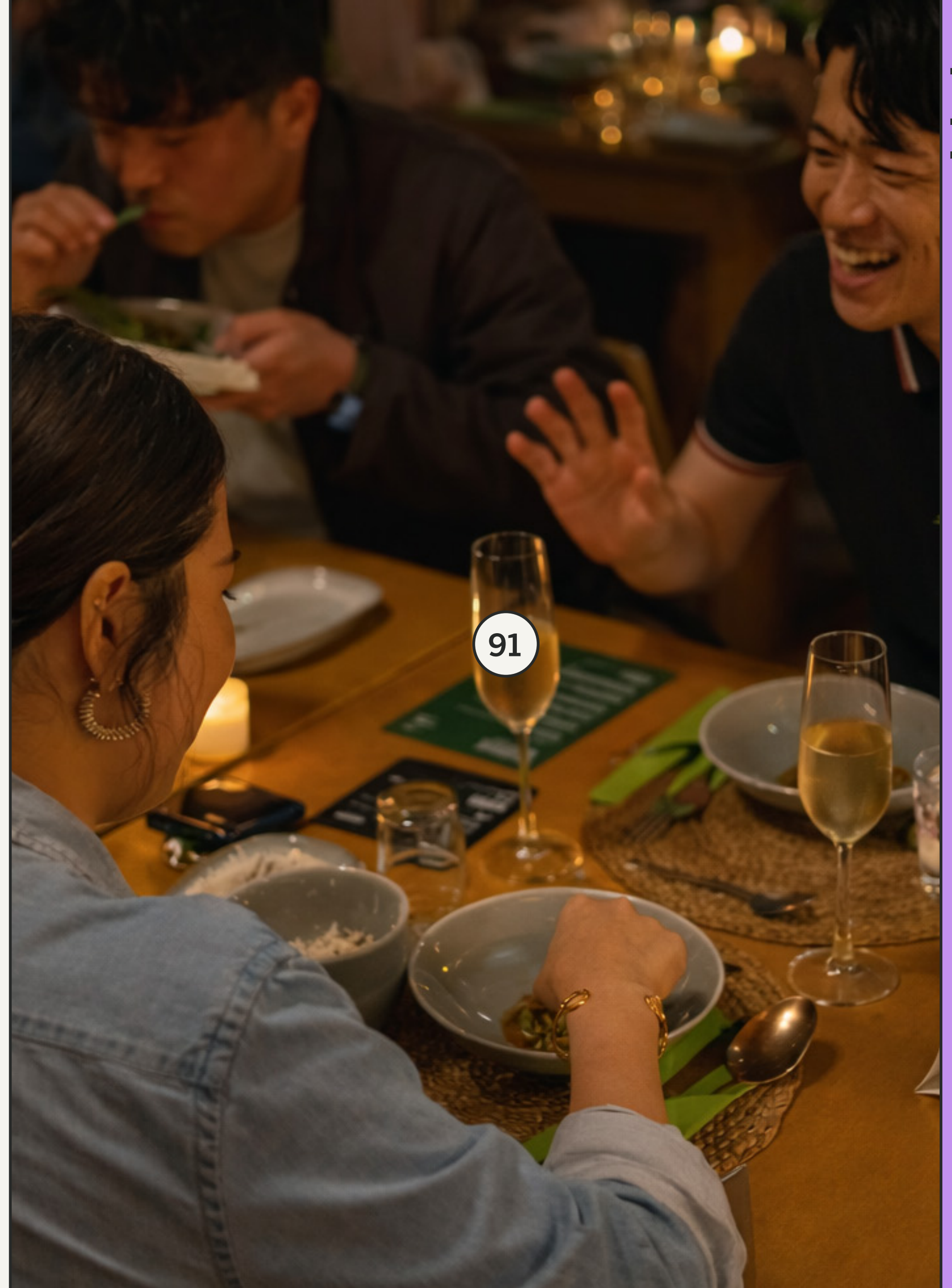
walk and ends with a 4am visit to the flower market. Historically malls facilitated fluid outings where a movie could lead to an arcade and then dinner. In the new age, spaces are doubling as mindful hubs.

“When you walk into The Courtyard you may see different identities: a Subko, a ramen bar, a wine bar. But it is the intentional coming together of projects in one space, they all have an artisanal attention to detail

90 **that attract a curated, discerning consumer.”**

- Akhila Srinivas

Time itself is the new status symbol, and those who can curate multiple chapters into a single outing signal taste and cultural fluency. Rigid schedules are losing cultural authority. People are choosing formats that respect agency.





MICRO

TREND

#02

Wellness

'O CLOCK

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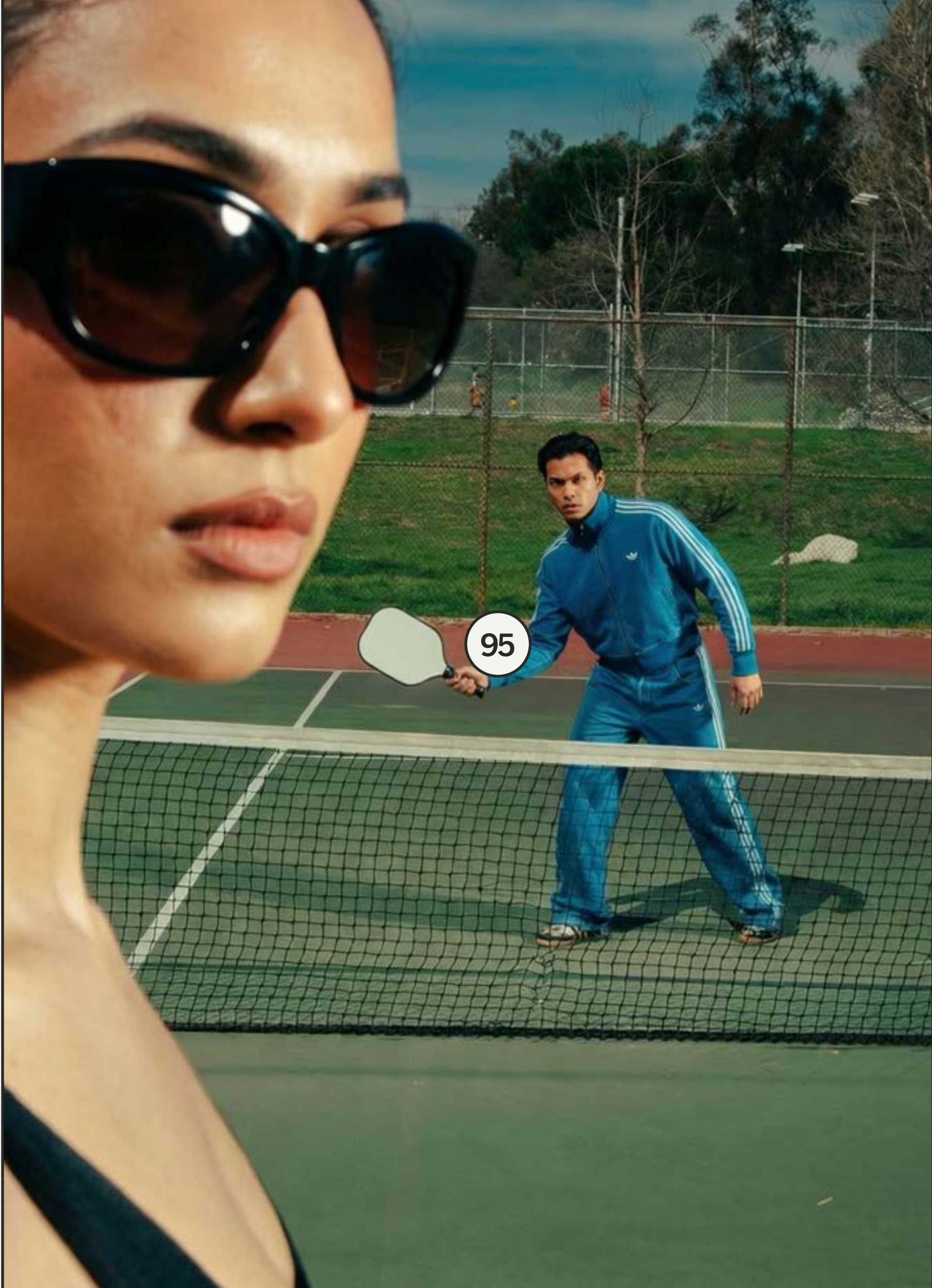
Uncertainty fuels the rhythm of everyday life. People are witnessing ecosystems collapse around them. The monsoons you once romanticised are now brutal enough to erase nostalgic landmarks. The public park you grew up playing in is now a multi-storey luxury development. At a time when so much in the external world feels out of control, people grasp at straws for a sense of stability. Here, the language of care is emerging as a soothsayer. People are actively prioritising the physical and mental self as a means for preservation.

This is visible in the reckoning of cocktail culture. Once youth was synonymous with late nights and painful hangovers. Today people are changing their relationship with alcohol. It is no longer as binary as being sober or not. It's about adding intentionality by checking in with your body. With wellness rising the ranks of priority, people assert agency over their evenings. Nights can end early to show up for dawn runs.

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But this quest for wellbeing doesn't imply missing out on social activity. It now includes immersion: a social bodylog, logged collectively.

Playing with friends was previously reserved for weekends. Now soft sports like pickleball allow connection and physical activity to merge into post work breaks. In Bengaluru, With Wlks blurs the line between networking and getting steps in by hosting founder meetups on long walks. The rise of solopreneurs, a booming freelance economy, and WFH culture is easing workouts into noon. Many gyms offer afternoon memberships while pilates and spin studios add midday classes. Fitness is not just vanity. It signals intentional investment in the self. People are no longer waiting for schedules to relax to add wellbeing. They bend time to prioritise care.



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Run clubs host post-workout raves and cafe mixers. In Ahmedabad, a women's only saree run combined a marathon with zumba and breakfast. Wellness is not isolated. It is increasingly anchored in group ⁹⁶communal exchange. This quality helps it break out of rigid schedules. Earlier, gym time was squeezed in before work or forced after a long day of meetings. Now it spills into social hang outs.

Brunch plans include a stopover at a clinic to refresh energy with IV drips or a ⁹⁷catch up over a session at the salt cave.

In October, Deepak Raj, the CEO of Hyrox India hosted a collaboration event with Peak State.

The winning wellness experiences will feel like side quests, unserious, story-forward and lightly chaotic. This is also where brands can own a rare lane: **joy + care without preachiness.**

“We organised this with a low entry barrier, for people who wanted something fun and engaging. It ⁹⁸ extended from 7pm ⁹⁹ to 2.30am people could shoot hoops together, skateboard, there was a dance floor and even a race. It was a mix of a festival meets sport to open up to different communities.”

- Deepak Raj

Double Double LIFE CULTURE

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This is not the era of unbridled hustle, and it most definitely isn't the era of absolute bed rotting. After years of oscillating between productivity as the protagonist and antagonist, the new aspiration is calculated balance. A culture is emerging where ambition and connection coexist without eclipsing the other. People are shaping routines to accommodate both passion projects and loved ones.

The ideal is to create a rhythm that honours multiple priorities rather than forcing a choice

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People have the appetite for more, & the industry caters to this. In response to this hunger for experience, & the shift in building a balanced routine, options for consumers like District's Buy-Now-Pay-Later, and other affordability alternatives allow consumers to sustain this lifestyle, & encourages them to experiment with new categories.

Holistic manifestation may be hinged to the luxury of flexible times, but the roots of the movement are visible.

People are returning to the intimacy of family. Restaurants that once focused on evening service are opening for daytime reservations to accommodate schedule-agnostic, multi-generational gatherings. Recognising this desire, the founders of Bengaluru’s buzzy bar Soka branched out to open the city’s new family-first fine dining restaurant Kalpaney. The menu intentionally spans from micro Indian cuisines to Thai and Italian, a reminder that families feature diverse tastes that should all be catered to.

Events are being designed for mixed-age participation. While concerts traditionally draw younger audiences, the Indian gig scene has witnessed nostalgic artists like Akon, Sunidhi Chauhan, and others. Many Gen Z first experienced this music through their parents,

making these events prime opportunities for shared quality time, a form of nostalgia for one generation and newslatgia for another. Similarly, as fitness grows as a priority, audiences blend workout routines to include family. Hyrox Mumbai saw many father-son and sibling duos participate as partners.

Artists, events, and experiences with existing fan bases have a headstart when it comes to world-building because they have existing mythology to build upon instead of starting from scratch. Bollywood movie re-releases are the clearest example, having seen a huge uptick in recent years essentially becoming huge sing-alongs for people seeking to relive their past, and offer chances to plug recall and spawn conversations.

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The freedom of elastic time supports relationships, productivity, and experiences. In an attempt to eventually access this luxury, people are establishing stronger boundaries at work and play.

The proliferation of learn to say no culture on the internet has created vocabulary for this conversation. Employees are gaining courage to challenge odd-hour asks in favour of mental and social wellbeing. After years of living in the this or that era, people recognise the light at the end of the tunnel is the beginning of the fluidity in taste. Spaces are responding to that higher stakes energy.

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In Bengaluru, The Courtyard holds a Naru, a wine bar, a Subko, a vinyl bar, and rotating chef residencies. It’s a palette, not a single venue. Being seen there lands as a shorthand: you keep up, you’re curious, you know where the city is moving. **“Travel and global media have strengthened people’s appetite for what’s more. They want each experience to make them feel special and choose events that add to their clout,”** explains founder Akhila Srinivas.

This is not restricted to the youth. The Courtyard hosts eat-what-you-watch film screenings and game dates for kids that become play grounds for signalling. “Parents push for sustainable activities that distill values because they see every event as a reflection of who they are.”

Retail has followed the same logic, morphing into hotspots of community. Sneaker brand Gully Labs has Baithak, a designated in-store gathering space. Crafts label Péro launches collections

through immersive exhibitions that (104) pull you into the trimmings and fabrics, so the making becomes part of the story you carry. Lifestyle brand Capsul hosts supper clubs inspired by street art and listening sessions to embody its worldview as something you can enter.

Even cinemas are leaning into immersion: collectible popcorn buckets, sing-along screenings, dine-in formats that fold food into the ritual. Status has started flowing away from price tags and logos and towards intentionality. You show up with discernment. You make a conscious choice to attach your personal image with it.

Analog Curation



is the new flex

It proves you’re not a passive bystander waiting for a trend to emerge. Rather you’re an active co-creator, sifting through events until you land on novelty.



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Revolt **AGAINST THE ROT**

A decade of hyper-digital living has left consumers with more than screen burnout, scroll fatigue, and brain rot. There's a growing, almost clinical awareness of what being too online does to loneliness, attention, interpersonal

confidence, and the basic ability to be present with other people. The touch grass impulse has been building for years. Now we're deep into the swing back, from screens to reality.

This turn is often framed as wellness, but the sharper driver is trust.

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Digital life can be manipulated, filtered, staged, and scaled. The physical world earns a new premium because it feels verifiable. Reality is the last vestige of humanness: its imperfections, its unpredictability, its tactility.

A room's energy can't be convincingly faked. The weight of an object can't be simulated. Awkwardness, friction, laughter, silence, these are still hard to counterfeit. Texture becomes truth. **Materiality becomes meaning.**

Once the physical world carries a trust premium, the people and systems that guide you through it become part of that trust. Drained by infinite scroll and infinite choice, curation starts to feel like relief. People want to be guided, not endlessly catered to. **109** They want someone to do the mental labour of taste: what's worth it, why it matters, where it lands best. **Less infinite scroll, more “here are three things worth your time.”**

This is why editorial voices, curators, intentional experiences, and small menus are rising as a cultural response, relief from the buffet. Restraint becomes value. Human judgement becomes the product.

This is also why anti-screen-time signalling keeps accelerating. Screen time reads as low status for a more specific reason than “uncool.” It signals low agency, being led by feeds instead of making choices. Being out in the world reads as authorship. And friction is sexy here because the physical world demands effort. You show up. You commit time. You hold eye contact. You learn how to be social again. You stay long enough for something real to happen.

The pendulum is swinging toward tactility in rebellion against digital disembodiment, and it’s showing up everywhere: in what people do, what they buy, and how they want to spend time together. Right now the signal is clear: We are observing a collective move away from flat, screen-based, algorithmic engagement and toward multisensory, participatory, memory-making experiences. In simpler terms, brain rot is losing its grip. Brain Bloom, activities that break dependency loops, restore attention through effort, and make you feel human again, starts to take precedence. Going out becomes a reward reset.

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80%

of people in India say they want to be treated as individuals with unique interests and preferences

Adobe, 2022

India’s private members’ club market is set to reach over \$100 million by 2027

Hotelier India, May 2024

In 2024, Indians spent

11%

of their daily time engaging in culture, leisure, media and sports vs 9.9% in 2019

Press Information Bureau, 2025

MICRO

TREND

#01

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THE Algoditch

For much of the 2010s, the dominant sense was sight. Experiences were designed to be aesthetic and Instagrammable, beautiful plates, neon signs, pop-ups built to be photographed more than lived. The counter-move now is to activate the senses the screen can't deliver: touch, smell, taste, sound, proximity. These become the new frontiers of luxury and belonging.

The Algoditch is what happens when people step out of algorithmic living and back into proximity. A perfect plate no longer finishes the job. People want to assemble it, learn the pairing, understand the sauce, feel the process. You see it in the rise of pottery cafés like The Pottery Lab in Mumbai, perfume-making workshops, ceramic-painting bars

replacing the Saturday-night brewery routine, and more avant-garde classes like carpet tufting and zine-making. Texture is the point.

From solo tactile hobbies to duo hobbies that double as date formats, our relationship with sensation has gotten more intense. Nike Run

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Club's collaborations with dating apps like Bumble sit right in that overlap, social impulse contained in an IRL ritual. Wake Up Juice by Hustlerani's picnic events bring young creatives together around a shared table, creating a live intersection of creator, brand, and community. Where digital culture prized visibility, the sensorial turn rewards presence. Experience is measured in texture, proximity, duration.

Activity-based formats like supper clubs, run clubs, and hobby circles push IRL socialisation precisely because scrolling doesn't fit the container. These are detoxes that don't feel punitive. Logging off becomes the fun part. And for urban young adults navigating high rates of loneliness across generations, these groups fill the void by designing connection through routine and shared effort.

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Running groups like Bhag Club in Delhi and 54 Running Club in Bangalore build fitness-first community. Supper clubs like The Lost Table in Gurgaon, Seré Supper Club in Chandigarh and Gurgaon, and Dasrarkhwan and Sakare in Bangalore treat culture and conversation as seriously as food. For those chasing a more elite crowd or a niche ritual, mahjong classes are spreading across metros, while private members' clubs like Soho House, Offline, and D'Monde continue capturing HNIs. In a culture of infinite content, the scarce thing is a room where you can't scroll.



Sidequest CORE

As discourse against subscription culture grows, Gen Z lives in a moment where ownership can feel distant. The counter-impulse shows up in physical media's comeback and the desire to own one-of-one objects made for you, often made by you. People want to get their hands dirty and create something that carries proof of participation: woodwork sessions, signature scent labs, phone-case making, cheese-platter styling.

Personalisation is hot, but the hunger beneath it runs deeper: disconnection from one’s unique humanity, plus exhaustion with subscribing to the same trends as everyone else, a kind of Mainstream Core Fatigue. The handmade object carries moral and emotional weight. Creation becomes authorship and agency. The bespoke shifts from luxury to intent. Objects become identity anchors, object memory, physical proof that something happened.

This is also where culture makes room for a renewed posture: **beginner energy is desirable again.** There’s cultural permission to be new at things.

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In 2025 alone
1,000,000
or 7.8/10 people of India explored new categories of engagement - built an appetite & headed out to experiment with genres & formats they hadn’t previously.

Beginner energy plus experimentation plus hobby culture becomes a socially acceptable way to meet people, reset identity, and rediscover the city without needing expertise. You see this with the rise in people exploring art exhibitions, museums, fitness engagements, new sports, workshops for the first time ever - all across the country. In other words: you don’t need mastery to belong. You just need motion. Craft culture has

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roots in the pandemic era, sourdough, kombucha, crocheted scarves, small acts of making as a way to feel in control. Now that impulse has matured into social formats and brand worlds.

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At the Gully Labs store in Delhi, an entire floor is built around interaction. The customisation table invites people to pick charms, laces, accents, each shoe becomes authored. A screen behind it ties craft to culture with a layer of spectacle, without replacing the work of making.

Go Rug Yourself's tufting studios across NCR offer an inclusive, hands-on space to choose a design, craft it onto a rug, learn tufting, and leave with a personalised memento. Bangalore's Not Just Bijoux hosts Playground, a series of community events where people attend matcha workshops, zhuzh up sneakers with charms and trinkets, and share orchid-themed drinks while experiencing founder Divya Jalan's pressed flower jewellery.

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In an age of AI-generated aesthetics, authored imperfection gains weight. You can't shortcut it. You have to make it.

TOUCH TO *Feel*

Tactility comforts because to tradition, slowness, algorithmic. This nostalgia layer, a figurative back-to-the-future, gives the trend its emotional charge. Analog hobbies like film cameras, vinyl listening events, physical photo albums, and reading physical books are resurfacing among Indian Gen Z.

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it feels like a return, something pre-

Crucially, these aren't clean replacements for the internet. They're rebellions staged inside it: film photographs shot on a film camera, developed, then photographed again on a smartphone and uploaded to Instagram. Analog becomes a statement precisely because it exists alongside digital. For pop-culture brands, this creates a new design brief. How do you translate a digital experience, an OTT series, a fandom,

a film, into something worth Every touchpoint has to be tactile, not merely visual. Custom popcorn buckets that double as collectibles, like PVR's limited-edition Deadpool and Wolverine buckets that reportedly sold out quickly, show how hunger for international-grade fandom objects is spilling into Indian theatres. Sing-along screenings and immersive film events that turn cinema into participatory theatre, like the Eras Tour Movie, give fandoms new reasons to gather IRL.

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sensorially experiencing?

Nostalgia remains a powerful lever. Re-releases and commemorative screenings awaken memory and novelty at once. This is where the tangible becomes the archive, experience residue you can hold.

Myth Making

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& EXPERIENCE RESIDUE

When tactility becomes the trust layer, the next desire is longevity. If it feels real, people want it to stick. This is where the next wave arrives: experiences designed as worlds, not moments, built through worldbuilding, lore, myth-making, ritual, and residue.

Today's consumer has access to everything and has "seen" everything. The question becomes: how do you offer someone, affluent, well-travelled, culturally fluent, something that doesn't evaporate when it ends? You give them narrative surface area. You give them the lore of watching a shift from (buy ticket, attend, leave) designed to be relived, the experience. We're transactional formats to extended ecosystems repeated, embedded into identity, and carried forward through objects, references, and rituals that outlast the night.

Validation keeps moving off-social. Identity still shows up online, but more as breadcrumbing, hints, fragments, residues of a life lived, not a life staged. The new proof is "you had to be there" energy: inside jokes, shared references, objects that carry story. The event becomes a cultural receipt you can't screenshot. The next wave belongs to lore-layer experiences that generate experience residue.

District has been experimenting with this too. Across key events, we introduced **District Cards**. Think player trump cards we all grew up collecting, except the “players” were artists and experiences. You could only get one if you actually showed up.

We even ran limited drops on an FCFS basis, and it got interesting fast. Over time, fans and communities online started collecting them, trading them, even reselling them. A metal card object turned into a status cue. Proof that you weren’t just aware of the moment, you were present for it.

Merch becomes part of the mythos, it becomes subtle signalling, while more novel merch leans into collectability.

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Long after the taste fades and the bill is paid, the object remains, the **experience residue** as status, proof you were part of the story.

India is unusually primed for shared micro-universes because tradition already functions as a mythology engine. The fake shaadi trend that popped up in 2025 is one expression, familiar codes re-skinned for a younger, myth-seeking audience. Bhajan clubbing among urban Gen Z hints at the potential of lore-heavy Bharatcore experiences, recognisable cultural grammar remixed with play. Subko Coffee Roasters’ Beta Bites, which nod to childhood toffee eclairs in collaboration with Peter Cat Recording Co., sits in this lane too: nostalgia used as a bridge into a broader brand world.

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Myth-making also shows up as meta-experiences, formats that extend the original in unexpected directions. Rolling Loud’s limited-edition menu collaboration with Veronica’s in Mumbai gave fans another way to literally sink their teeth into the festival. Serendipity Arts Festival did smaller invite-only cultural shows across cities, like a ghazal night at Safdarjung’s Tomb in Delhi, to build lore, broaden footprint, and keep the world alive between editions.

These aren’t marketing moments. They make people feel like residents of a universe, not visitors.

Creators become crucial infrastructure here. Parasocial intimacy has reach, but it doesn't fully satisfy belonging. So creators keep building physical bridges, turning followership into offline communities through meetups, festivals, niche gatherings. We've observed this with the likes of Peakst8: the internet becomes the entry point, trust gets cemented in person. In an AI-saturated landscape, that conversion matters even more, because the one thing you can't automate is a room full of real people sharing a real moment.

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The hard part is authenticity. Myth-making can't be manufactured overnight. Lore has to feel rooted in ethos and evolve through participation, not prescription. Done with care, it creates a self-sustaining loop of culture, commerce, and community, where ticket sales are just entry and the real value sits in the ecosystem that forms around the experience.

Once revolt against the screen becomes mainstream posture, the next battleground is longevity. The bar won't be "was it fun?" The bar becomes "did it leave residue?" The next wave belongs to experiences that keep living, as lore, objects, rituals, and shared references.

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WORDS OF CAUTION & AN INVITATION TO

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Go Out

We should be honest about what we're doing here. Any report like this risks turning something lived into something packaged. The minute you name a behaviour, you start compressing it. Real scenes become "formats." Intimacy becomes "insight." You start believing you're documenting culture, when you're also contributing to the machinery that over-produces it.

Still, the shift is real. People aren't only bored of the internet. They're hungry for proof. For texture. For nights that can't be reduced to a story slide or a photo dump. Moments that change your mood in your body, not your feed.

This report has blind spots by design. It can only hold what we saw, who we spoke to, what surfaced in the time we had. It's interpretation, not prophecy. Trend-mapping doesn't tell you what will happen. It sharpens your ability to notice what's already changing, so you can respond with intention instead of defaulting to templates.

Treat this as a working draft of the moment. Culture will move again. We will too. So take it as a nudge, not a manual. Close the tab. Pick one thing this week that requires you to show up. Reserve the table. Take the walk. Stay longer than you planned. Talk to someone you didn't arrive with. Let it be awkward. Let it be unfinished. Let it be real.

The great outdoors await. Go out, with

district
BY ZOMATO